the much-required empirical evidence."

Growing dependence on private vehicles has implications for congestion, pollution, fuel consumption and road safety, particularly for vulnerable road users such as two-wheeler riders. Yet the public transport operators expected to provide an alternative are themselves struggling financially.

The Funding Gap

A Ministry of Road Transport and Highways study of 58 state road transport undertakings found that although they collectively owned 147,032 buses, only 106,293 were operated, on average, during 2021-22, translating into fleet utilisation of 72.29 per cent. Their combined net losses stood at Rs 30,191.93 crore, with just two undertakings reporting profits.

Amit Bhatt, managing director (India) at the International Council on Clean Transportation, points to the key concern: "The biggest problem is, where do I find that additional and sustained source of revenue?" Without sustained funding, operators struggle to maintain fleets, increase frequencies or improve reliability. Poor service discourages passengers, weakening demand and further undermining the financial viability of bus operations. As per Bhatt's calculations, India has only 40,000 public transport buses. "Beijing itself has that number." He also questions why governments apply different financial yardsticks to buses and metros. "If we apply the bus logic—that there is no demand, no usage—to metros, no metro will make sense. But with metros, we tend to take a long-term view, it would seem."

Consider the scale of investment.

THE SHORTCOMINGS

- Bus fleets are underutilised, with financial losses crippling state transport undertakings and limiting services
- Infrequent, unreliable bus services and poor connectivity push commuters towards private vehicles
- Fragmented administration undermines coordination between buses, metros and suburban rail networks



AFP



"India has a total of 40,000 buses for public transport, while Beijing alone has that many. We need to not just add more buses but also create better roads for them"

— **AMIT BHATT,** *Managing Director (India), International Council on Clean Transportation*

HOW INDIA MOVES

TRAVEL EXPENDITURE

RISING COST OF THE COMMUTE

Household budgets are stretched by travel expenses, while poor connectivity and long journey times constrain access to jobs and opportunities

By **JUMANA SHAH**

For Indian households, the daily commute is emerging as one of the biggest claims on the monthly budget after food. The National Household Travel Survey 2025-26 offers a measure of that burden. A worker travelling to a fixed workplace spends an average of Rs 785 a month: Rs 1,044 in urban India against Rs 612 in rural India, about 71 per cent more in cities. Urban students, too, spend Rs 617 a month getting to class, compared with Rs 361 in rural India. Women workers pay Rs 533 a month against Rs 835 for men, a gap that may reflect shorter journeys rather than cheaper ones.